DM guide – setting DCs and difficulty · SRD 5.2.1

The **DC** (Difficulty Class) is the **threshold to reach** to succeed on a D20 Test. The DM picks it by task: Very Easy (5) to Nearly Impossible (30). For a **spell**, the save DC is **8 + spellcasting modifier + Proficiency Bonus**.

Set a DC **before** rolling, announce the roll, and only ask for a check if failure has a cost.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Very Easy 5 · Easy 10 · Medium 15.
2. Hard 20 · Very Hard 25 · Nearly Impossible 30.
3. Spell DC: **8 + mod. + proficiency**.
4. The DC is set **before** the roll.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 keeps the same DC tiers and states the DM only asks for a roll if the outcome is uncertain.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD gives few examples per tier. Fix: keep a reference table (see next page) and adapt it to your table.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the obstacle in a sentence to justify the DC (“the rope is wet”).

Step 1 – Assess the task:

Obvious, common or exceptional for an adventurer?

Step 2 – Choose the tier:

5, 10, 15, 20, 25 or 30 by difficulty.

Step 3 – Adjust:

Favorable or unfavorable conditions: Advantage or Disadvantage rather than changing the DC.

Step 4 – Announce:

State the ability, skill and, if you wish, the DC.

Step 5 – Consequence:

Say what failure costs before rolling.

Example: climbing a rough stone wall: DC 15; a smooth wall in the rain: DC 20.

DCS AND DIFFICULTY (5E, 2024 RULES) – DC TABLE

Difficulty	DC · examples
Very Easy	5 · obvious task (open a stuck door)
Easy	10 · climb a rough wall
Medium	15 · pick a standard lock
Hard	20 · swim in a strong current
Very Hard	25 · disarm a complex trap
Nearly Impossible	30 · a legendary feat
Spell DC	8 + spellcasting mod. + Proficiency Bonus
Spell attack	Bonus = spellcasting mod. + proficiency
Passive Perception	10 + mod. + proficiency

⚠ Common questions:

What default DC?

15 (Medium) for a serious task.

A spell's DC?

8 + ability modifier + proficiency.

Should I announce the DC?

DM's choice; useful for new players.

A DC above 30?

Rarely: for near-impossible feats.

Advantage or change the DC?

Advantage for favorable conditions.

DCs and level?

DCs don't rise with level; characters' bonuses do.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Hiding the DC

Announce the DC or not. **Option**: announce it.

Flexible DC

Scale the DC to level. **Option**: keep fixed tiers.

Automatic failure

Impossible task: no roll. **Option**: refuse the roll.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Tiers

Tiers run from 5 to 30 in steps of 5.

Spells

Spell DC = 8 + mod. + proficiency.

Useless check

No roll if failure has no consequence.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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